Policy & Strategy Lab

Reading List

Readings are short and attached to specific days. Each essential reading is an article or a chapter, not a book, and comes with a question to bring to class: the theory question on that day's slides. Optional readings are for participants who want more. Instructor background reading is listed in the bibliography.

Readings by day

Day	Theme	Essential	Optional	Question to bring
1	Problems, clients and decisions	Rittel and Webber, "Dilemmas in a General Theory of Planning" (1973). Read the ten properties of wicked problems.	Conn and McLean, Bulletproof Problem Solving (2018), chapter 1.; Bardach and Patashnik, A Practical Guide for Policy Analysis, part I, step one: define the problem.	Whose definition of the problem are you adopting, and what would count as solved?
2	Defining the problem	Bardach and Patashnik, A Practical Guide for Policy Analysis, part I, step one: define the problem.	Sen, Development as Freedom (1999), introduction and chapter 1.; PRS Legislative Research: browse the bill and budget summaries for your sector.	Are you measuring access to a resource, or what people are actually able to do with it?
3	Structuring with issue trees	Conn and McLean, Bulletproof Problem Solving (2018), the chapter on disaggregating problems with logic trees.	Minto, The Pyramid Principle, the chapter on grouping ideas (edition to confirm).	
4	Finding causes	Andrews, Pritchett and Woolcock, Building State Capability (2017), the chapter on problem deconstruction, which uses the fishbone diagram (open access).	Pratham, Annual Status of Education Report: the summary of the most recent national report, for the common case.	
5	Systems and scope lock	Andrews, Pritchett and Woolcock, Building State Capability (2017), the chapter on capability traps and isomorphic mimicry (open access).	Meadows, Donella H. Thinking in Systems: A Primer (2008), chapter 1.	Would the obvious fix copy the form of a programme that worked elsewhere without the capability behind it?
6	Jurisdiction, money and delivery	Pritchett, "Is India a Flailing State?" (2009), the opening sections.	Kapur, "Why Does the Indian State Both Fail and Succeed?" Journal of Economic Perspectives 34, no. 1 (2020).; The Constitution of India: the Seventh, Eleventh and Twelfth Schedules.	At which link in the delivery chain does intent at the top stop becoming action on the ground?

Day	Theme	Essential	Optional	Question to bring
7	Actors and political economy	Lipsky, Street-Level Bureaucracy (1980), preface and chapter 1, or the introduction to the expanded edition.	Ostrom, Governing the Commons (1990), chapter 3 on design principles.; Fritz, Kaiser and Levy, Problem-Driven Governance and Political Economy Analysis (World Bank, 2009), the framework section.	Which rules actually govern behaviour here, and what will frontline workers really do?
8	Prioritising issues	Conn and McLean, Bulletproof Problem Solving (2018), the chapter on prioritisation and pruning the tree.	Simon, Herbert A. "A Behavioral Model of Rational Choice." Quarterly Journal of Economics 69, no. 1 (1955).	Given limited time and attention, what is good enough to investigate, and what will you knowingly leave out?
9	Hypotheses	Bardach and Patashnik, A Practical Guide for Policy Analysis, part I, step two: assemble some evidence.	Heuer, Richards J., Jr. Psychology of Intelligence Analysis. Center for the Study of Intelligence, 1999. Chapter 8, analysis of competing hypotheses.	
10	The workplan	The methods note or data documentation for the main dataset in your workplan: read how it was collected and at what level it is representative.	A PRS Legislative Research budget analysis for your sector or state.	
11	Finding and judging evidence	The methods chapter or note of your main survey or administrative source.	The CAG audit reports for your state and sector, searched on the CAG website.	
12	What the numbers say	Spiegelhalter, David. The Art of Statistics: Learning from Data. London: Pelican, 2019. Chapter 1.	Schwabish, Jonathan. Better Data Visualizations. New York: Columbia University Press, 2021. The chapters on choosing a chart.	
13	Experience and comparison	Dolowitz, David P., and David Marsh. "Learning from Abroad: The Role of Policy Transfer in Contemporary Policy-Making." Governance 13, no. 1 (2000).	Andrews, Pritchett and Woolcock, Building State Capability (2017), on isomorphic mimicry, revisited.	
14	Testing the hypotheses	Toulmin, Stephen. The Uses of Argument. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1958. The chapter on the layout of arguments.	Heuer, Psychology of Intelligence Analysis (1999), chapter 8, revisited.	
15	Synthesis and the diagnostic memo	Minto, The Pyramid Principle, the chapters on the pyramid structure and on introductions (edition to confirm).	Rumelt, Good Strategy/Bad Strategy (2011), the chapter on the kernel of good strategy.	Does your argument contain a diagnosis, a guiding policy and coherent action, or is it a list of goals?
16	Generating options	Brown, Tim. "Design Thinking." Harvard Business Review, June 2008.	Hall, "Policy Paradigms, Social Learning, and the State" (1993), the section on orders of change.	Are you adjusting settings, changing instruments or changing goals?
17	Choosing between options	Moore, Creating Public Value (1995), the chapter on defining public value.	Lindblom, "The Science of 'Muddling Through'" (1959).; Flyvbjerg and Gardner, How Big Things Get Done (2023), on reference-class forecasting.	Does the option create public value, can it win legitimacy and support, and is there the capacity to deliver it?

Day	Theme	Essential	Optional	Question to bring
18	Designing for delivery	Rogers and Blenko, "Who Has the D? How Clear Decision Roles Enhance Organizational Performance." Harvard Business Review (2006).	Reeves, Haanaes and Sinha, Your Strategy Needs a Strategy (2015), the chapter on the adaptive approach.; Andrews, Pritchett and Woolcock, Building State Capability (2017), on problem-driven iterative adaptation.	Which links in your theory of change are assumptions, and what will frontline workers actually do with the plan?
19	Measurement and the pitch	Kingdon, Agendas, Alternatives, and Public Policies, the chapter on the policy window.	The results framework or indicator list published for your scheme, if one exists: compare its indicators with yours.	Is there a window for this recommendation, and which stream is missing?
20	The defence	None set	Your own Analyst Development Tracker: read the codes that recurred across the four gates before writing the report.	

Full bibliography

Chicago Notes and Bibliography style. **Status:** *Checked* means bibliographic details were confirmed against a publisher, catalogue or official site in November 2026. *Verify* means the entry is given from established knowledge and must be checked against the title page before it is quoted in teaching material or reports. Page numbers are given only where the range of a journal article is well established.

Source	Used on	Status
Anderson, Lorin W., and David R. Krathwohl, eds. A Taxonomy for Learning, Teaching, and Assessing: A Revision of Bloom's Taxonomy of Educational Objectives. New York: Longman, 2001.	Course design	Verify
Andrews, Matt, Lant Pritchett, and Michael Woolcock. Building State Capability: Evidence, Analysis, Action. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2017.	Days 4, 5, 13, 18	Verify (open access)
Bardach, Eugene, and Eric M. Patashnik. A Practical Guide for Policy Analysis: The Eightfold Path to More Effective Problem Solving. 6th ed. Thousand Oaks, CA: CQ Press, 2019.	Days 1, 2, 9; Week 4	Checked; a 7th edition (2024) is reported
Biggs, John. "Enhancing Teaching through Constructive Alignment." Higher Education 32, no. 3 (1996): 347-64.	Course design	Verify
Brown, Tim. "Design Thinking." Harvard Business Review, June 2008.	Day 16	Verify
Colby, Susan, Nan Stone, and Paul Carttar. "Zeroing In on Impact." Stanford Social Innovation Review, 2004.	Day 18	Checked (authors, title, year)
Cole, Martin, and Greg Parston. Unlocking Public Value: A New Model for Achieving High Performance in Public Service Organizations. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley, 2006.	Library card 37	Checked (authors, title, year)
Conn, Charles, and Robert McLean. Bulletproof Problem Solving: The One Skill That Changes Everything. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley, 2018.	Days 1, 3, 8	Checked against listings; confirm year

Source	Used on	Status
Dolowitz, David P., and David Marsh. "Learning from Abroad: The Role of Policy Transfer in Contemporary Policy-Making." Governance 13, no. 1 (2000).	Day 13	Verify
Doran, George T. "There's a S.M.A.R.T. Way to Write Management's Goals and Objectives." Management Review 70, no. 11 (1981).	Day 19	Verify
Flyvbjerg, Bent, and Dan Gardner. How Big Things Get Done. New York: Currency, 2023.	Days 17, 18	Verify
Fritz, Verena, Kai Kaiser, and Brian Levy. Problem-Driven Governance and Political Economy Analysis: Good Practice Framework. Washington, DC: World Bank, 2009.	Day 7	Verify
Hall, Peter A. "Policy Paradigms, Social Learning, and the State: The Case of Economic Policymaking in Britain." Comparative Politics 25, no. 3 (1993): 275-96.	Day 16	Verify
Heuer, Richards J., Jr. Psychology of Intelligence Analysis. Washington, DC: Center for the Study of Intelligence, 1999.	Days 9, 14	Verify
HM Treasury. The Green Book: Central Government Guidance on Appraisal and Evaluation. London: HM Treasury, 2022.	Library card 36	Verify current edition
Kapur, Devesh. "Why Does the Indian State Both Fail and Succeed?" Journal of Economic Perspectives 34, no. 1 (2020): 31-54.	Day 6	Checked
Kingdon, John W. Agendas, Alternatives, and Public Policies. Boston: Little, Brown, 1984.	Day 19	Verify; consider the updated edition
Leinwand, Paul, and Cesare Mainardi. The Essential Advantage: How to Win with a Capabilities-Driven Strategy. Boston: Harvard Business Review Press, 2011.	Library card 42	Checked (publisher listing)
Lindblom, Charles E. "The Science of 'Muddling Through.'" Public Administration Review 19, no. 2 (1959): 79-88.	Day 17	Verify
Lipsky, Michael. Street-Level Bureaucracy: Dilemmas of the Individual in Public Services. New York: Russell Sage Foundation, 1980.	Days 7, 18	Verify; an expanded edition exists
Mangla, Akshay. Making Bureaucracy Work: Norms, Education and Public Service Delivery in Rural India. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2022.	Instructor background	Verify
Meadows, Donella H. Thinking in Systems: A Primer. White River Junction, VT: Chelsea Green, 2008.	Day 5	Verify
Merton, Robert K. "The Unanticipated Consequences of Purposive Social Action." American Sociological Review 1, no. 6 (1936).	Day 5	Verify
Minto, Barbara. The Pyramid Principle: Logic in Writing and Thinking. London: Pearson.	Days 3, 15	Confirm edition and year
Moore, Mark H. Creating Public Value: Strategic Management in Government. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1995.	Day 17	Verify
Muralidharan, Karthik. Accelerating India's Development: A State-Led Roadmap for Effective Governance. Gurugram: Penguin Viking, 2024.	Instructor background	Checked (publisher and year)

Source	Used on	Status
Ostrom, Elinor. Governing the Commons: The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990.	Day 7	Verify
Pritchett, Lant. "Is India a Flailing State? Detours on the Four Lane Highway to Modernization." HKS Faculty Research Working Paper RWP09-013. Cambridge, MA: Harvard Kennedy School, 2009.	Day 6	Verify
Reeves, Martin, Knut Haanaes, and Janmejaya Sinha. Your Strategy Needs a Strategy: How to Choose and Execute the Right Approach. Boston: Harvard Business Review Press, 2015.	Day 18	Verify
Rittel, Horst W. J., and Melvin M. Webber. "Dilemmas in a General Theory of Planning." Policy Sciences 4, no. 2 (1973): 155-69.	Day 1	Verify
Rogers, Paul, and Marcia Blenko. "Who Has the D? How Clear Decision Roles Enhance Organizational Performance." Harvard Business Review 84, no. 1 (2006).	Day 18	Verify
Rumelt, Richard P. Good Strategy/Bad Strategy: The Difference and Why It Matters. New York: Crown Business, 2011.	Day 15	Verify
Schwabish, Jonathan. Better Data Visualizations: A Guide for Scholars, Researchers, and Wonks. New York: Columbia University Press, 2021.	Day 12	Verify
Sen, Amartya. Development as Freedom. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1999.	Day 2	Verify
Simon, Herbert A. Administrative Behavior. New York: Macmillan, 1947.	Day 8	Verify
Simon, Herbert A. "A Behavioral Model of Rational Choice." Quarterly Journal of Economics 69, no. 1 (1955): 99-118.	Day 8	Verify
Spiegelhalter, David. The Art of Statistics: Learning from Data. London: Pelican, 2019.	Day 12	Verify
The Behavioural Insights Team. EAST: Four Simple Ways to Apply Behavioural Insights. London: Behavioural Insights Team, 2014.	Library card 31	Checked
The Bridgespan Group. "Intended Impact and Theory of Change." December 2020.	Day 18	Checked
Toulmin, Stephen. The Uses of Argument. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1958.	Day 14	Verify
Weiss, Carol H. "Nothing as Practical as Good Theory: Exploring Theory-Based Evaluation for Comprehensive Community Initiatives for Children and Families." In New Approaches to Evaluating Community Initiatives, edited by James P. Connell, Anne C. Kubisch, Lisbeth B. Schorr, and Carol H. Weiss. Washington, DC: Aspen Institute, 1995.	Day 18	Verify

Indian data and documents: where to look

Check the current round, reference year and level of representativeness of every source before using it. Several major surveys are between rounds, and many estimates are valid only at state level.

Source	Producer	Good for
National Family Health Survey	Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, with the International Institute for Population Sciences	Health, nutrition, family welfare, household conditions; state and district estimates for some indicators
Periodic Labour Force Survey	National Statistics Office, Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation	Employment, participation, wages
Household Consumption Expenditure Survey	National Statistics Office	Consumption, living standards
UDISE+	Ministry of Education	School enrolment, teachers, infrastructure, by school and district
National Achievement Survey	Ministry of Education	Learning outcomes in sampled grades
Annual Status of Education Report	Pratham and the ASER Centre	Foundational reading and arithmetic, rural districts
Crime in India and related reports	National Crime Records Bureau	Recorded crime; read the methods notes on recording
Census of India	Office of the Registrar General and Census Commissioner	Population, housing, amenities; check the status of the next census
Health infrastructure and human resources statistics	Ministry of Health and Family Welfare	Facilities and posts filled, by state
Scheme management information systems and dashboards	Implementing ministries	Coverage, outputs, payments; administrative data
Output-Outcome Monitoring Framework and Outcome Budgets	Ministry of Finance with NITI Aayog's Development Monitoring and Evaluation Office	Official output and outcome indicators for central schemes
National Data and Analytics Platform	NITI Aayog	Harmonised datasets from many sources
Open Government Data Platform (data.gov.in)	Government of India	Downloadable datasets from ministries
Audit reports	Comptroller and Auditor General of India	Performance and compliance audits by state and sector
Social audit reports	State social audit units	Field verification of scheme delivery, especially the rural employment guarantee
Standing committee reports	Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha secretariats	Scrutiny of ministries' demands for grants and schemes
Bill and budget analyses	PRS Legislative Research	Readable summaries of bills, budgets and state finances
Budget analyses	Open Budgets India (Centre for Budget and Governance Accountability)	Union and state budget data
State finances	Reserve Bank of India, annual study of state budgets	Fiscal position and spending of states

Source	Producer	Good for
City rankings and urban data	Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (for example, Swachh Survekshan)	Comparative urban service indicators; read the method